paths were distinct but could be pursued simultaneously or in parallel. Vivekananda tried to combine all these in himself. He pursued his own divinity by discipline and effort, deep study, reading and reflection, and huge physical effort that included walking the length and breadth of India with nothing but a staff, a water pot and his own charisma to sustain him.

He was a profoundly moral figure, with none of the indulgences that modern Indian 'godmen' have become known for; as Adi Shankara preached, he lived by a code of truth, purity, celibacy and unselfishness that anchored his *shraddha* (faith). Although many of his deeply committed followers were women, he treated them as sisters and daughters, irrespective of their age, and lived the celibate life of a *brahmachari*, seeing intimate relations as incompatible with his mission of spiritual service. In this he remained essentially a monk, but unlike his preceptor Ramakrishna he was no other-worldly figure: a compelling speaker and a magnetic presence, Swami Vivekananda was focused on human behaviour in the real world he saw around him. He argued that it is an insult to preach religion to a man with an empty stomach, and for many in India, he said, God will only appear as a loaf of bread.

The Vedanta, interpreted in comprehensible contemporary terms, became the vehicle for his preaching. As Vivekananda explained: 'Each soul is potentially divine. The goal is to manifest this Divinity within by controlling nature, external and internal. Do this either by work, or worship, or mental discipline, or philosophy—by one, or more, or all of these—and be free. This is the whole of religion. Doctrines, or dogmas, or rituals, or books, or temples, or forms, are but secondary details.'

Vivekananda lived up to this precept himself: work, worship, mental discipline and philosophy, he mastered them all. He believed that spiritual realisation needed the awakening of the human will; this required him to adopt a path of pursuing spirituality through service. Worldly success was important, but such success could only be the outcome of focused thought and action. It is important to remember that Swami Vivekananda—despite being a spiritual figure, despite being a disciple of the immortal Ramakrishna Paramahamsa, despite being a *sannyasi* who travelled throughout India and taught the message of